ponder the access they may have had to the imperial harem and whether they were able to paint some of the royal women from life. That the royal women were collectors and patrons of manuscripts is well known. Salima Sultan Begum had in her personal collection a copy of Amir Khusro's *Duval Rani va Khizr Khan*, illustrated during the early reign of Akbar, perhaps even under her direct guidance. Hamida Banu Begum was another voracious collector of books and manuscripts and as for Gulbadan, she would write a book herself. The *Anwar-i Suhayli*, with its animal fables and moral messages from the *Panchatantra*, was deemed to be highly suitable to teach Salim and his siblings the nuances of human nature and Akbar commissioned a simpler version of the same stories called the *Iyar-e Danesh* (Pearls of Wisdom) for the education of the princes.

At the same time, as this effervescent activity had begun to flourish in Fatehpur, Akbar saw an opportunity to finally rout the troublesome Afghan menace. Afghans had been settling in Bengal for a while, as we saw, keeping away from imperial authority in the north-west. They had been encouraged to migrate by the Bengal sultan Nusrat Shah who used them to create a useful buffer zone between himself and the Mughals. In 1564, Taj Khan Karrani had founded an Indo-Afghan dynasty in this region where he cautiously maintained a submissive attitude towards the increasingly powerful Mughals. But when Sulaiman Karrani Afghan had died in 1572, creating a power vacuum in Bengal and Bihar, his son Daud, as the new Sultan of Bengal, no longer even pretended to wear the 'outer garment of submission' to Akbar and had struck coins and had the khutba read in his own name. This was insolence that could not be tolerated and Akbar went first to Ajmer to seek the blessings of the saint for the war he was proposing to wage. At this time he organized the building of kos minars (milestones) and the sinking of wells at regular intervals along the Agra-Ajmer road. At Ajmer, Akbar appointed Rai Ram Das to the diwani of Ajmer sarkar and then returned to Fatehpur to prepare for battle.